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Initiatives by Pakistan organisations to bridge the gender digital divide.

➤ Introduction:

The gender digital divide refers to gender biases in technology products, the tech industry, and digital education. It affects women and people of diverse gender identities' access to and advancement in computing fields.

➤ Institutes:

Several organisations in Pakistan are actively working to bridge the gender digital divide by empowering women through technology and digital literacy. Here are some notable initiatives:

Government

- 1) Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication (MoITT).
- 2) Punjab Commission on the Status of Women (PCSW).
- 3) National Information Technology Board (NITB).
- 4) Pakistan Telecommunication Authority (PTA).
- 5) Pakistan Council for Science and Technology (PCST).

Non-Governmental Organisation

- 1) Aga Khan Foundation.
- 2) Aurat Foundation.
- 3) Digital Rights Foundation (DRF).
- 4) CIRCLE.
- 5) Tech Valley Abbottabad.

➤ Description:

The detailed description of the institutions are as follows:

Government

- 1) Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication (MoITT)

❖ Establishment and location:

It was **established in 2002**. The **Government of Pakistan** formed it to oversee and promote the development of the IT and telecom sector in the country and its Headquarters is in **Islamabad, Pakistan**.

❖ **Workings:**

Its workings are as follows:

1) **Digital Gender Inclusion Strategy (DGIS)**

Launched with Pakistan Telecommunication Authority (PTA).
Aims to reduce the gender digital gap by 50% in three years.

2) **National Freelancing Training Program (NFTP)**

Provides digital skills training for women to start online careers.

2) **Punjab Commission on the Status of Women (PCSW)**

❖ **Establishment and Location:**

It was **established in March 2014** by the **Government of Punjab, Pakistan**. Its headquarters is in **Lahore, Punjab**.

❖ **Workings:**

Its workings are as follows:

1) **Employment Facilitation Center**

Assists women who are looking for jobs by providing career guidance, CV writing assistance, and job search techniques.

2) **Gender Management Information System (GMIS)**

Tracks gender discrimination in the public sector and monitors the implementation of women's policies in Punjab.

3) **National Information Technology Board (NITB)**

❖ **Establishment and Location:**

It was **established in 2014** through the **merger of the Pakistan Computer Bureau (PCB) and the Electronic Government Directorate (EGD)**. It was formed under the **Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication (MoITT)**. It is in **Islamabad, Pakistan**.

❖ **Workings:**

Its workings are as follows:

1) **Initiatives Like ICT for Girls**

In collaboration with Universal Service Fund (USF) provides coding and cloud computing training for young girls.

2) Digital Inclusion Programs

Encourages digital inclusion programs to create IT opportunities for women.

4) Pakistan Telecommunication Authority (PTA)

❖ Establishment and Location:

It was **established in 1996** under the **Pakistan Telecommunication (Re-organization) Act 1996**. It was **formed by the Government of Pakistan** to regulate the establishment, operation, and maintenance of telecommunication systems. Its headquarters is in **Islamabad, Pakistan**.

❖ Workings:

Its workings are as follows:

1) Digital Gender Inclusion Strategy (DGIS)

It launched (DGIS) in collaboration with the Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication (MoITT).

Aims to reduce the gender digital gap by 50% over three years.

Focuses on digital literacy programs, affordable internet access, and women-centric policies.

2) Education Center

Establishes women's education centres where girls learn coding, web development, and freelancing skills.

Also, initiate Support programs that provide IT education to young girls in underprivileged areas.

5) Pakistan Council for Science and Technology (PCST)

❖ Establishment and Location:

It was **established in 1961**. **Formed by the** Government of Pakistan. Its headquarters is in **Islamabad, Pakistan**.

❖ Workings:

Its workings are as follows:

1) Encourage Women's Participation

Promotes science and technology initiatives, including efforts to encourage women's participation in STEM fields and reduce the gender gap in

technology sectors.

Non-Governmental Organisation

1) Aga Khan Foundation

❖ Establishment:

It was established by **Aga Khan in 1967**.

❖ Workings:

Its workings are as follows:

1) Aga Khan Education Services (AKES)

It has various programs that support education, digital literacy, and skills development, particularly in underprivileged and remote areas of Pakistan.

One of its famous services is **Aga Khan Education Services (AKES)**, which incorporates digital learning tools in schools, benefiting both male and female students.

Their initiative is improving women's access to digital tools and technology-based learning.

2) Aurat Foundation

❖ Establishment:

It was established by **Naeem Mirza and Shaheen Ashfaq in 1986**.

❖ Workings:

Its workings are as follows:

1) Gender Equality and Empowerment

The Aurat Foundation is a well-known women's rights organization in Pakistan.

While its primary focus is on gender equality and empowerment, it has also been involved in initiatives related to digital literacy and women's access to technology.

It has worked on projects advocating for women's digital rights, online safety, and increasing access to ICT (Information and Communication Technology) for women in rural and urban areas.

3) Digital Rights Foundation (DRF):

❖ Establishment:

It was established by **Nighat Dad in 2012.**

❖ Workings:

Its workings are as follows:

1) **Education and Online Harassment**

To educate Pakistani internet users, particularly women, on protecting themselves from online harassment and to advocate for digital rights and online freedom. In 2016, DRF launched a **cyber-harassment helpline**, addressing over 16,000 complaints and offering pro-bono legal assistance to victims

4) CIRCLE

❖ Establishment:

It was established by **Sadaf Abid in 2014.**

❖ Workings:

Its workings are as follows:

1) **She Loves Tech**

A global technology start-up competition aimed at supporting women-led businesses and startups.

2) **Tech Karo**

A training program providing digital skills such as coding and digital marketing to women from underprivileged areas, promoting their inclusion in the tech industry.

5) Tech Valley Abbottabad

❖ Establishment:

It was established by **Umar Farooq in 2015.**

❖ Workings:

Its workings are as follows:

1) **Digital Skills and Participation**

The organization has conducted digital literacy programs targeting women, aiming to equip them with essential digital skills and promote their participation in the digital economy.
